

US Equity Strategy

10 learnings from this earnings season: Strong

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Related strategy notes:

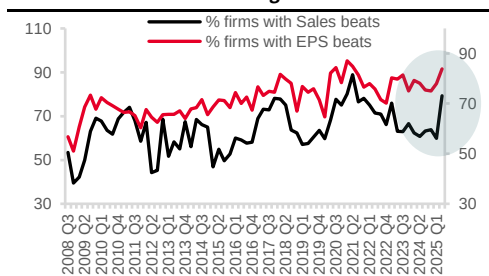
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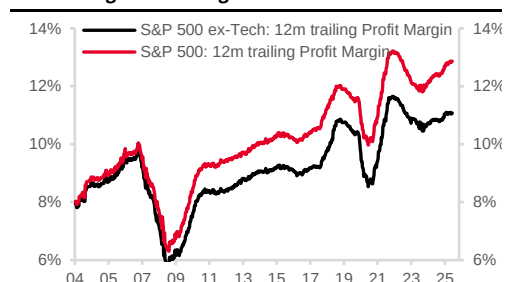
- 1) **Biggest sales beat in 4 years:** 30% of firms have now reported, with 84% beating EPS and 79% beating top-line estimates. In past years, profit margin surprises mainly drove the beats, but the latest earnings show the strongest top-line surprises in 4 years (cover chart).
- 2) **Rational behaviour:** Stocks that beat have outperformed by 0.9%, while misses underperformed by 1.5%, reflecting classic market rationality.
- 3) **Profit margins broadening:** S&P 500 profit margins continue to rise, including the ex-Tech sectors (cover chart).
- 4) **Highest EPS revision ratio in 3 years:** The EPS revision ratio stands at 1.4, its highest level in 3 years, indicating 14 upgrades for every 10 downgrades.
- 5) **US leads:** S&P 500 EPS revisions have led global revisions for 10 weeks, outperforming global EPS 74% of the time over 5 years. Reported EPS is at a 2-year high versus other benchmarks, such as European stocks.
- 6) **USD offsets tariffs:** A 10% USD drop adds a 4% positive EPS impact, while a 10% tariff rate subtracts 3%. Improving trade deficits and a weak USD policy goes hand in hand.
- 7) **Sector and style trends:** Communications and Tech firms have all beaten EPS and sales; Materials and Consumer sectors lag. Quality and Momentum styles lead; Value and Small-cap are lagging.
- 8) **Rate-sensitive** sectors and styles are lagging as they await Fed cuts.
- 9) **Corporate activity is strengthening:** S&P 500 revenue per employee has hit new highs. Capex to sales is rising across sectors; leverage is at its lowest since 2014. Buybacks are up 16%, and dividends up 6% over 12 months. M&A and IPOs are edging up gradually. Corporate signals show firm corporate activity but no peak equity fears yet
- 10) **Our view on S&P 500:** The secular backdrop of structurally higher nominal growth is firmly intact post the global fiscal policy shifts. Strong returns from S&P 500 last 3 months proved our our US outlook, [crisis of confidence is short-term....](#) The S&P 500 is now only a few points away from our end-2025 target. However, we still see upside risk as the Fed card has not fully played out, either on curve steepening or the unfinished business of weakening USD. Moreover, the peak excitement for US stocks involves the broadening of the index performance. S&P 500 should range: 5500-6750 and we see bubble risk only beyond 7500 ([see pg 22 of our US Equity Slidepack](#))

Sales and EPS beats are strong



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

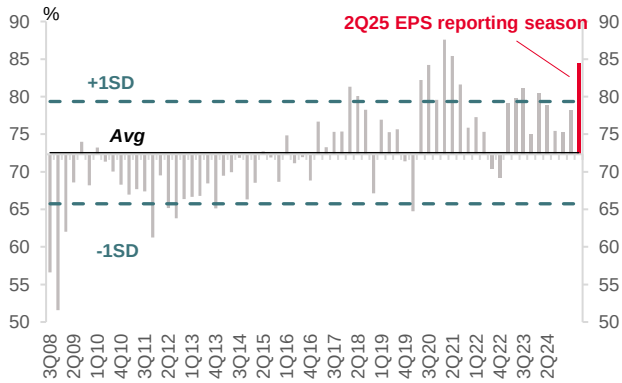
Profit margins are rising outside of Tech too



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

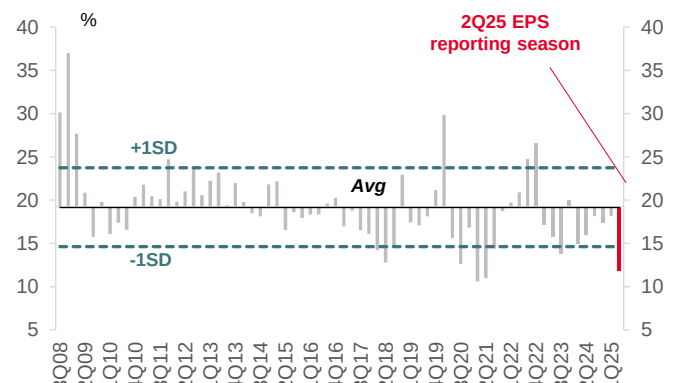
US Earnings Summary

Chart 1. S&P 500: % of firms beating EPS estimates



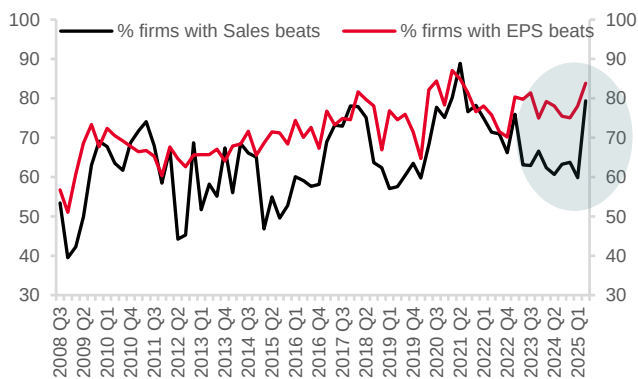
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 2. S&P 500: % of firms missing EPS estimates



Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 3. Sales and EPS beats show strong margin resilience



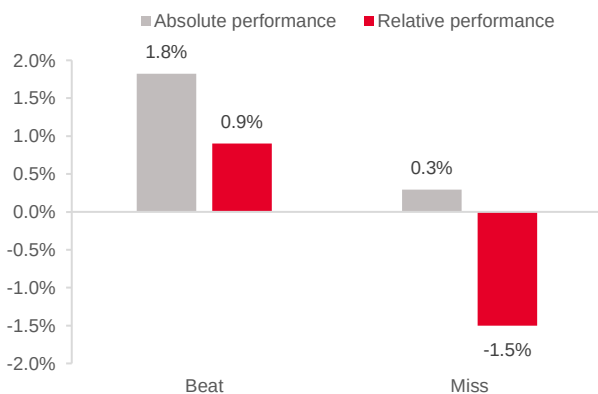
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 4. EPS and Sales beat per sector

Sector	Total Companies	Number Reported	% with EPS beat	% with Sales beat
Communication	24	8	100%	100%
Tech	68	14	100%	100%
Real Estate	31	4	100%	75%
Health Care	60	12	92%	100%
Industrials	78	32	88%	72%
Financials	74	39	87%	77%
Energy	22	6	83%	83%
Staples	38	11	73%	64%
Cons. Discr.	51	21	67%	86%
Materials	26	6	50%	33%
Utilities	31	2	50%	50%
S&P 500	503	155	84%	79%

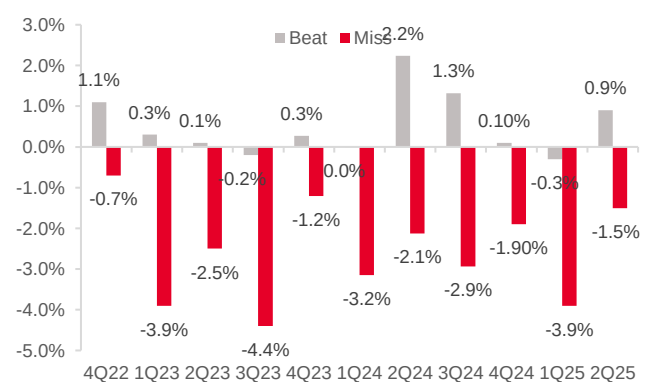
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 5. Performance of firms that beat or miss estimates in the current season (+/- 2 days)



Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 6. Relative performance of firms that beat or miss estimates over last six seasons



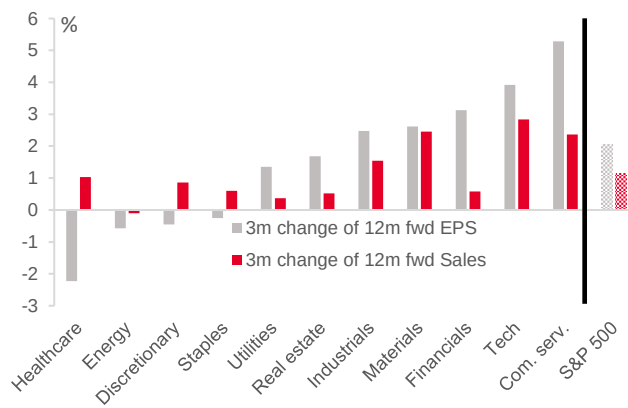
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 7. Sector and style EPS beats this season

	Reported (%)	EPS % positive surprises
Communication Services	33%	100%
Information Technology	33%	100%
Real Estate	33%	100%
Health Care	20%	92%
Industrials	41%	88%
Financials	53%	87%
Energy	27%	83%
Consumer Staples	29%	73%
Consumer Discretionary	41%	67%
Utilities	23%	50%
Materials	23%	50%
All	31%	84%
Momentum	25%	92%
Quality	28%	90%
Growth	26%	86%
Risk	32%	82%
Size	25%	77%
Value	30%	74%

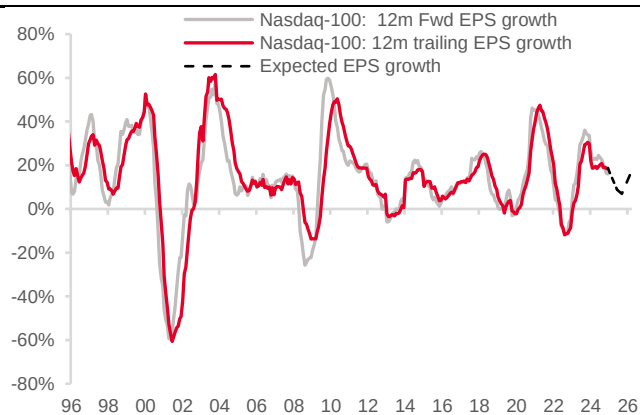
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 8. Three-months change in 12-month forward EPS



Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 9. Nasdaq-100 EPS growth to show profit growth rate slowdown for next 6-months



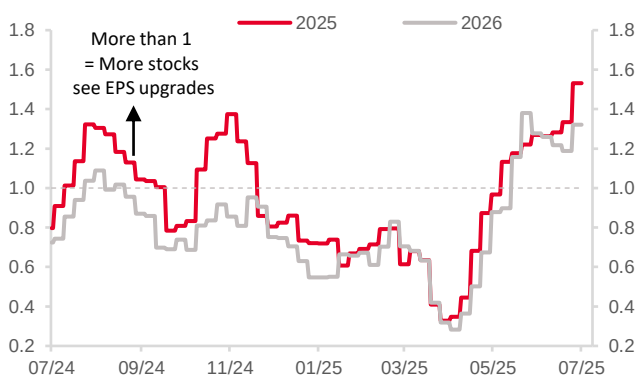
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 10. Magnificent-7 earnings release date

Name	2025 Q1	2025 Q2	2025 Q3	2025 Q4
Tesla	22 Apr	23 Jul	15 Oct	28 Jan
Alphabet	24 Apr	23 Jul	28 Oct	03 Feb
Meta	30 Apr	30 Jul	22 Oct	04 Feb
Microsoft	30 Apr	30 Jul	28 Oct	04 Feb
Amazon	01 May	31 Jul	23 Oct	29 Jan
Apple	01 May	31 Jul	23 Oct	29 Jan
Nvidia	28 May	27 Aug	12 Nov	12 Feb

Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 11. S&P 500 EPS revision ratio (breadth measure of EPS)



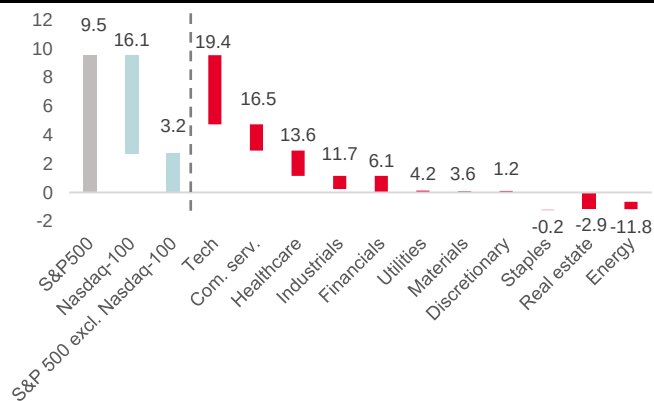
Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 12. S&P 500 EPS revision ratio per sector



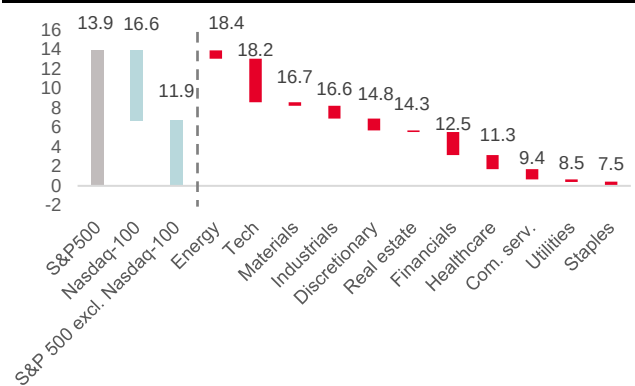
Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 13. Contribution to 2025 S&P500 earnings growth per sector (numbers represent expected EPS growth)



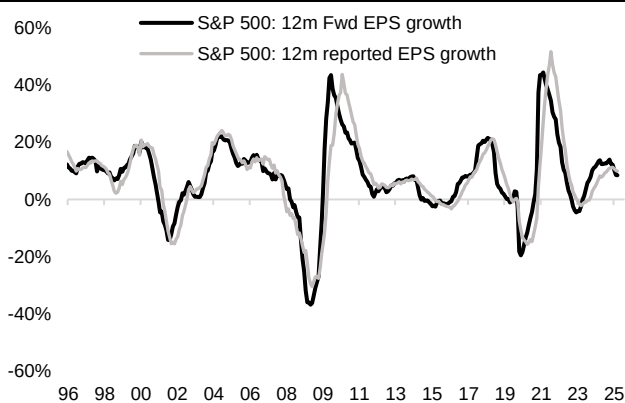
Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Chart 14. Contribution to 2026 S&P500 earnings growth per sector (numbers represent expected EPS growth)



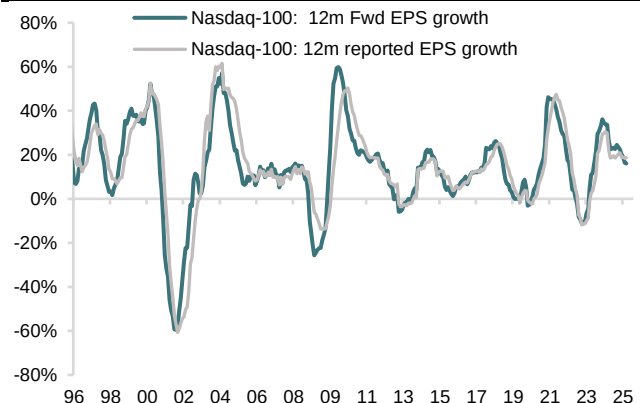
Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

S&P 500 EPS growth: expectations and reported



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Nasdaq-100 (NDX) EPS growth: expectations and reported



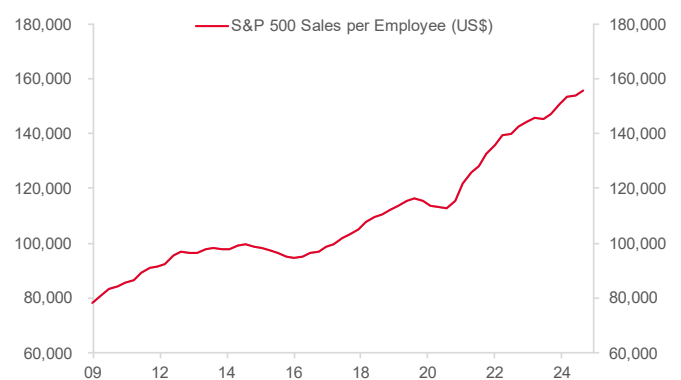
Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

S&P 500 Number of Employees



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

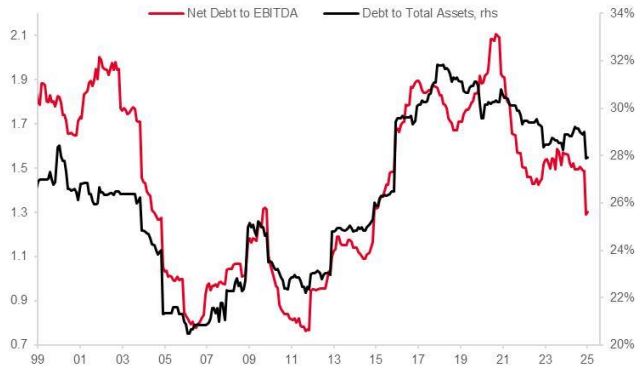
S&P 500 Revenue per Employees



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

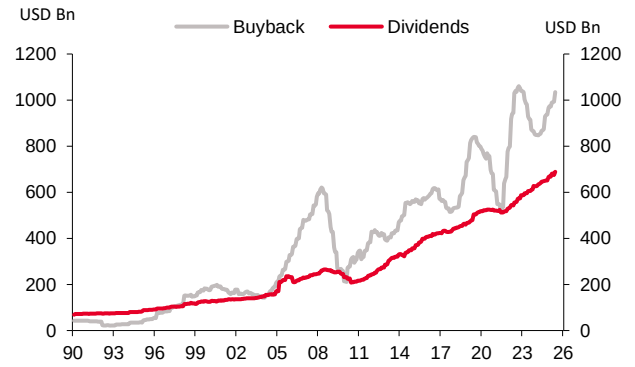
Corporate Activities: Firming up

S&P 500: Leverage ratio: Lowest since 2015



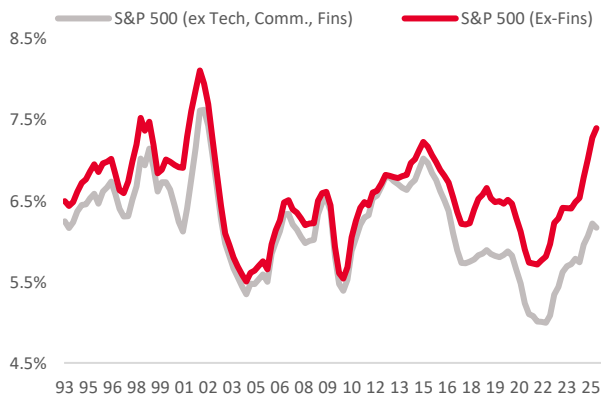
Source: Bloomberg, FactSet, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

S&P 500 buyback +16% and Dividends +6% over last 12-months



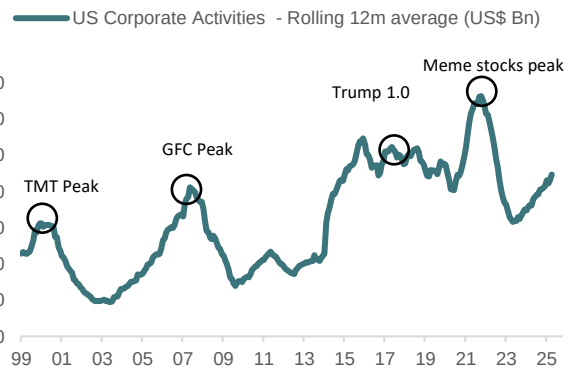
Source: FactSet, Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Capex to Sales is strong for Tech but improving for ex-Tech sectors too



Source: Bloomberg, FactSet, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

Corporate activities (M&A + IPO), +23% last 12-month



Source: Bloomberg, FactSet, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

SG View on US Equities

US Equity Outlook

Indicators	Impact on Risk Assets	Comments
Macro fundamentals		
GDP & Inflation	=	GDP growth slowing vs. last 2 years; Inflation higher but stable
Liquidity	+	Fed on the verge of rate cutting cycle (4 cuts expected in 1 year)
US Political risk	=	Far from midterm elections
Geopolitical risk	+	Trade war, tension in the Middle East
Earnings growth		
Sales growth	+	Sales growth steady at +5%
Corporate margins	+	At new highs; Revenue per Employee rising
EPS vs. Rest of the V	+	S&P 500 at 30-year highs vs. Global EPS cycle
Valuation		
vs History	--	22x 12m Fwd PE vs. long-term average of 16x
vs Bond Yield	-	Equity Risk Premium near cycle-lows but not in 'bubble' territory
vs RoW	-	1.5x more expensive than Europe
Corporate Policy		
Balance sheet	++	Private sector leverage is falling and net-debt equity ratio is lowest since 2014
Dividend	=	Dividend yield at 1.2% but growing at 6.6% last 12-months
Buybacks	=	Net Buyback yield at 1.5%, growing at 16% last 12-months
M&A	+	M&A Cycle is in early stages of coming back; Regulatory backdrop is net positive
Flows	+	Strong inflows into Equities and Fixed Income funds (+\$380bn YTD)
SG House View	+	S&P 500 growth backdrop, increase in corporate activities offsets the valuation concern until the FED rate cutting-cycle is closer to the end

Source: SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

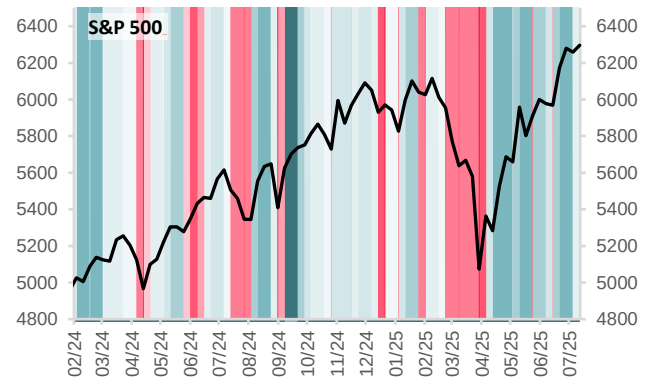
SG Turning Point Signals

SG Breadth of x-asset Indicator summary

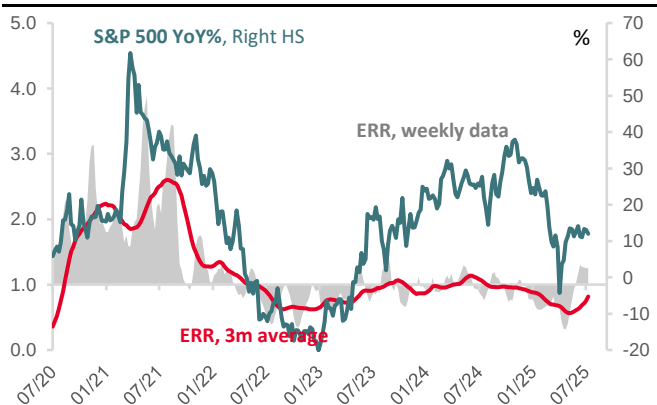
	18-Jul-25	11-Jul-25	04-Jul-25
Equities			
Cyclical vs Defensive	-	-	+
High vs Low Risk	+	+	+
% of members > 50d	+	+	+
Credit			
US HY	-	+	+
Euro HY	+	+	+
Commodities			
Copper vs Gold	-	-	+
Oil	+	+	-
FX			
AUD	-	+	+
SEK	-	-	+
Cryptocurrencies	+	+	+
Volatility			
VIX (inverted)	+	-	+
% Positive	55%	64%	91%

SG Breadth of Cross-Asset Indicator: percentage of cross-asset signals that have a positive 4-weeks change. Colors refers to the SG Breadth of Cross-Asset Indicator: from red (0%) to blue (100%). Latest data as of 07/02/2025. Source: Bloomberg, Refinitiv SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

SG Breadth of x-asset Indicator with S&P 500

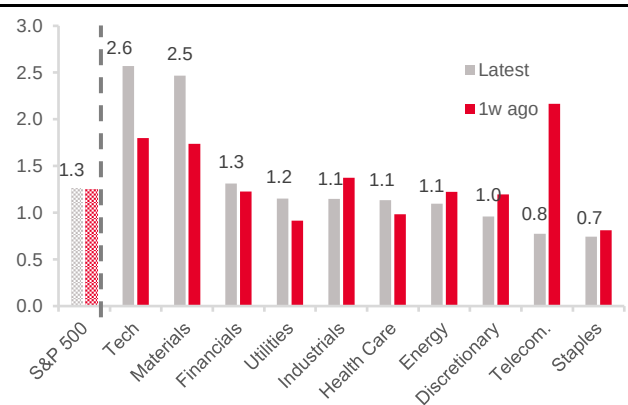


S&P 500 EPS revisions



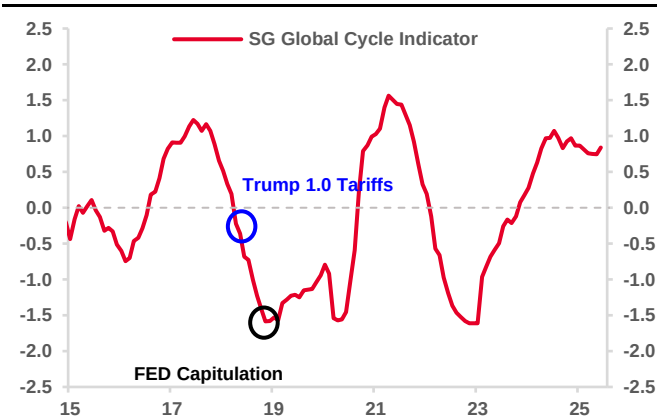
Source: SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

S&P 500 EPS revisions per sector



Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

SG Global Cycle indicator: still above average and saw first improvement since Q4'24



Source: Refinitiv, Bloomberg, OECD, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy

SG Sector Signals: Neutral Cyclical vs. Defensives

SG Sector Signals: July'25		Factor ranking (1= best)				
Sector	Signal	Overall rank	Earnings	Price Momentum	Contrarian to sell-side ratings shifts	Macro
Staples	Bullish	1	9	6	1	1
Real Estate	Bullish	2	5	9	2	3
Industrials	Bullish	3	4	2	6	9
Communication	Bullish	4	3	1	9	8
Utilities	Neutral	5	8	5	7	2
Technology	Neutral	6	1	3	8	10
Financials	Neutral	7	2	4	10	7
Health Care	Bearish	8	6	11	5	4
Materials	Bearish	9	7	7	11	5
Energy	Bearish	10	11	10	4	6
Discretionary	Bearish	11	10	8	3	11

Source: Refinitiv, SG Cross Asset Research/Equity Strategy. Four-factor framework. 1) Earnings = EPS revision ratio (breadth measure) and EPS momentum (magnitude measure). 2) Price momentum = 3- and 6-month changes. 3) Sell-side ratings revision: current vs 12-month average. 4) Macro = beta preference against the SG Global Cycle Indicator.

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APPENDIX

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